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1. MARKING THE ECG ROUTE

A. Purpose of Marking the ECG Route

The primary purpose of marking the ECG is to guide trail users along our route. Identifiable trail markers assure travelers on the Greenway, at intersections and forks in the trail and also along long stretches in between, that they are proceeding along their desired route and in the correct direction. While extensive sections of the ECG are still on road, providing frequent markings is crucial to keeping ECG users on the route.

Trail markers will also enable travelers along the route to distinguish between the spine and other strands in the ECG route system. A signage protocol for this is currently under development.

Trail markers also serve to raise public awareness of the East Coast Greenway by identifying a given local trail segment as part of the ECG. Frequent posting of the ECG “two trees” logo helps to develop public awareness of our “brand.” Thus, we want to maximize their visibility along our route.

B. ECG Trail Markers

i. development of the unique ECG trail marker

Trail markers using the “east coast map” design (figure 1.0) had been used to mark some designated sections of the ECG prior to 2002. Some of these may still remain in place today but should be replaced with the new “two trees” logo marker.



Fig. 1.0: ECG trail marker graphic,
circa 1999



Fig. 1.1: ECG trail marker graphic,
developed in 2002

While the former marker showing the idealized route along the coastline is an interesting graphic, it does a poor job as an easily identifiable, clear and memorable marker for user guidance. Recognizing this, the ECG “two trees” logo (figure 1.1) was developed with a grant from the Robert Wood Johnson Foundation and professional help from Pentagram Design of New York City during 2002 and adopted by the ECGA Board of Trustees in November 2002. This logo was then chosen as a very legible and unique design that would be an effective trail marker. The image has been trademarked by the ECGA.



ii. ECGA trail marker options

a. signage for marking the spine route

ECGA large spine route trail markers are intended for use at trailheads, such as parking lots or trail access points at public transit nodes. Being larger, they are more visible, and therefore better for leading people toward the trail. However, they may also be used as standard trailside identification signs if the trail managing authority so desires. Large spine route trail markers are .063 gauge aluminum back with the graphic and text silkscreened onto engineer-grade vinyl sheeting.



*Fig. 1.2: large spine route marker
Florida to Maine (northbound)
shown at approx. 30% actual size
actual size: 5.5" x 15"*



*Fig. 1.3: large spine route marker
Maine to Florida (southbound)
shown at approx. 30% actual size
actual size: 5.5" x 15"*

Two options are available, Florida to Maine and Maine to Florida. These should be facing the appropriate direction on the trail – that is, Maine to Florida for southbound travel and Florida to Maine for northbound travel. Signs are pre-drilled with 3/8" holes at intervals permitting mounting on steel u-channel posts or square tubular posts. Brackets or mounting clamps may be used to attach these signs to round tubular posts (aka "pipe posts"), which do not have pre-drilled holes for signage installation.

When desired, these signs may be used in tandem with the ECGA directional arrow, medium gauge (.070) plastic:



*Fig. 1.4: Directional Arrow
shown at approx. 30% actual size
Actual diameter: 3.5"*

ECGA small spine route trail markers, as seen below, are intended for use as route identification signage. They should be installed at regular intervals along the trail. What is deemed “regular” will differ from place to place, depending on factors including frequency of cross-streets, intersecting trails, and presence of other trail markers (such as those bearing the name of the local trail). This is discussed in greater detail in section A5, “Making a signage plan”. Small spine route trail markers are .180” fiberglass, opaque, with a non-relective glossy finish, with the graphics embedded in the fiberglass.



*Fig. 1.5: small spine route marker
Florida to Maine (northbound)
shown at approx. 50% actual size
actual size: 3.5" x 9.55"*



*Fig. 1.6: small spine route marker
Maine to Florida (southbound)
shown at approx. 50% actual size
actual size: 3.5" x 9.55"*



The ECGA can make another version of the small sign available which does not include the web address, if the trail managing authority objects to its inclusion.



*Fig. 1.7: small spine route marker
Florida to Maine (northbound)
No web address
shown at approx. 50% actual size
actual size: 3.5" x 9.5"*



*Fig. 1.8: small spine route marker
Maine to Florida (southbound)
No web address
shown at approx. 50% actual size
actual size: 3.5" x 9.5"*

At 3.5" wide, the small spine route markers are designed to be mounted either on wood 4x4 posts or on steel u-channel or square tubular posts. As with the large markers, they can be used in tandem with directional arrows (fig. 1.4) where desirable.



The ECGA prefers to use its standard stand-alone trail markers to mark the East Coast Greenway. ECG users will be attuned to seek out the ECG marker as they wind their way from city to city. Just as long-distance hikers on the Appalachian Trail seek out the white blaze that marks the AT, ECG users will seek out the blue-and-green “tall rectangle” of the ECG for assurance that they are on track.

Occasionally, circumstances do not allow for ECG trail markers to be installed. This may be the case in a historic district or where sign density is a problem. In such cases, the ECG trail marker graphic may be incorporated into other signage.

For example, the Blackstone Valley National Heritage Corridor is a historic district between Worcester, Mass. and Providence, RI, managed by a partnership including the National Park Service, 2 state governments, and dozens of municipalities, businesses, and nonprofit agencies. One of the special features of the Heritage Corridor is the Blackstone River Bikeway, which is a designated segment of the East Coast Greenway. National Park Service planners, in cooperation with the Rhode Island Department of Environmental Management and the ECGA, are developing a signage plan for the bikeway which will integrate the ECG trail marker graphic into Heritage Corridor signs (see figs. 1.9 & 1.10).



Fig. 1.9: Blackstone River Bikeway “Site ID”, as adopted by RIDEM and the NPS

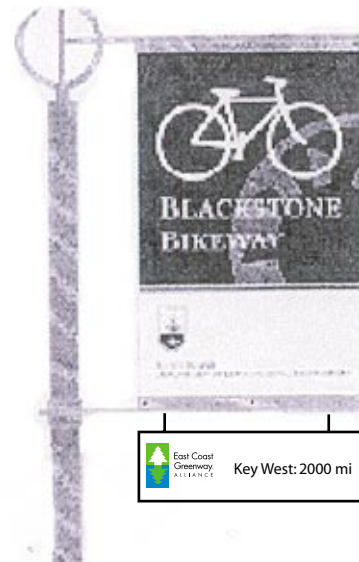


Fig. 1.10: Blackstone River Bikeway “Site ID”, proposed alteration to identify as ECG

Integration of ECG identity graphics in this way can be a seamless and attractive method for limiting the proliferation of signage along a trail.



b. signage for marking the interim on-road route

The East Coast Greenway is 21% complete as an off-road route (Dec. 2005). To mark the four-fifths of the ECG that is currently interim on-road routing, the East Coast Greenway Alliance has designed interim route signs. Standard ECG trail markers should not be placed along the interim route, as it may give the public the false impression that the East Coast Greenway is an on-road facility.



*Fig. 1.11: large interim route marker
Florida to Maine (northbound)
shown at approx. 30% actual size
actual size: 5.5" x 16.4"*



*Fig. 1.12: large interim route marker
Maine to Florida (northbound)
shown at approx. 30% actual size
actual size: 5.5" x 16.4"*

All interim route markers may also be used in tandem with the directional arrow (fig. 1.4). These markers are .063 gauge aluminum back with the graphic and text silkscreened onto engineer-grade vinyl sheeting.



The ECGA also offers small signs for marking on-road routes. As with the trail markers, they are available with or without the web address. These markers are .180" fiberglass, opaque, with a non-relective glossy finish, with the graphics embedded in the fiberglass.



*Fig. 1.13: small interim route marker
Florida to Maine (northbound)
shown at approx. 50% actual size
actual size: 3.5" x 10.425"*



*Fig. 1.14: small interim route marker
Maine to Florida (southbound)
shown at approx. 50% actual size
actual size: 3.5" x 10.425"*



The small interim route markers are seen here without the web address, for use when a trail's managing authority finds it objectionable.



*Fig. 1.15: small interim route marker
Florida to Maine (northbound)
no web address
shown at approx. 50% actual size
actual size: 3.5" x 10.256"*



*Fig. 1.16: small interim route marker
Maine to Florida (southbound)
no web address
shown at approx. 50% actual size
actual size: 3.5" x 10.256"*

As with the trail markers, the interim on-road route markers are pre-drilled at intervals designed to allow them to work with u-channel and square tubular posts.

- PLACEHOLDER: c. marking non-spine (alternate) ECG routes (policy TBD)
 PLACEHOLDER: d. marking "future" (under development) ECG trails (policy TBD)
 PLACEHOLDER: e. marking roads/trails that lead to the ECG (policy TBD)

**iii. Securing trail markers to install****a. ordering from the ECGA**

ECG Route Marker Order Form

NAME OF TRAIL: _____

CONTACT NAME: _____

MAILING ADDRESS: _____

PHONE & EMAIL: _____

Item	Quantity	Cost per unit	SUBTOTAL
Large Spine Route Marker - Maine To Florida		\$7.62	
Large Spine Route Marker - Florida To Maine		\$7.62	
Small Spine Route Marker - Maine To Florida		\$4.85	
Small Spine Route Marker - Florida To Maine		\$4.85	
Small Spine Route Marker (no Web) - Maine To Florida			
Small Spine Route Marker (no Web) - Florida To Maine			
Large Interim Route Marker - Maine To Florida			
Large Interim Route Marker - Florida To Maine			
Small Interim Route Marker - Maine To Florida			
Small Interim Route Marker - Florida To Maine			
Small Interim Route Marker (no Web) - Maine To Florida			
Small Interim Route Marker (no Web) - Florida To Maine			
Directional arrows \$0.94			
TOTAL:			\$

NOTE: Shipping costs will vary depending on destination. We will send an invoice to cover those costs after sending the signage. Unless you specify otherwise, we will send via USPS parcel post.

If possible, PLEASE attach a map showing where signs will be posted

If paying by check (payable to ECGA), mail form and payment to:

East Coast Greenway Alliance, 27 North Rd, Wakefield, RI 02879

If paying by credit card (MasterCard or Visa), please fill out this form and either mail to the address above, fax to 401-789-4625, or email to info@greenway.org

☐ MasterCard ☐ Visa Card number _____

Expiration date: ____ / ____

Signature: _____

NOTE: Our supplies are limited, so please request only the number you plan to install. Please see the ECGA Signage Manual to view illustrations of the different signage options. Contact the ECGA (info@greenway.org / 401-789-4625) with any questions.



b. directions for agencies wishing to produce ECG signage in-house

The East Coast Greenway Alliance will provide mechanical drawings to agencies wishing to create ECG signage in their own sign shops. Mechanical drawings (Illustrator EPS) include registrations for screw/bolt holes, guides for trim, and Pantone color codes. Contact the Alliance for more information: 401-789-4625 or info@greenway.org.



Figs. 1.17 & 1.18: Union County, NJ produced route markers in-house for the route through their county in northern NJ, as seen in these two photos. Please note that the mounting of signs on utility poles is not ordinarily legal. Also note that the Greenway sign in the photo below is the same width as the u-channel post on which it is mounted. Federal regulations demand that signs be a minimum distance from the ground to prevent road/trail users from hitting them. Being flush with the post may allow for signs to be posted below that minimum height.





iv. trail marker installation guidelines

PLACEHOLDER: **a. who is responsible for trail marker installation?** (pending)

PLACEHOLDER: **b. what must happen prior to trail marker installation?** (pending)

c. make a plan for posting trail markers

Get organized. Before placing markers along your trail (and after you have secured all permissions) you will need to spend some time working out where and how to post them.

Please be aware of the **different kinds of markers** for marking trail versus on-road sections, and the options for sizes and materials available (see pp. 4-10). Place the larger signs at trail heads and important access points and on informational kiosks if they exist. Place smaller signs along the trail as “reminders” to people that they are still on the Greenway. All markers have some common information on them: our logo, and the phrases “Linking Cities” and “Maine to Florida” or “Florida to Maine”. The version that says **Maine to Florida** should be placed on your trail oriented to be seen by southbound users; the one that says **Florida to Maine** should be oriented for northbound users.

Field check the route to determine signage locations and to prepare a map of where the markers will be posted. Marking this map is important both for the initial installation of the markers and to provide locations for those checking in the future to be sure the markers are still in place.

- Secure a base map from the ECGA Cartographer (401-789-4625).
- Gather together a couple of pens, red and green markers, and a clip board.
- Gather a friend or agency staffer (or two) to accompany you in the field. Plan to walk or cycle the route. Be sure to have plenty of time for this important fieldwork.
- Start at one end of the trail and begin to locate both the larger and smaller signage posting sites.

Guidelines for locating signs:

- Post signs on the right-hand side of the trail, facing trail users.
- Look for existing sign posts, fenceposts or poles on which to fasten the signs ECGA does not (at this time) provide sign posts and we aim to limit clutter, so using existing poles is desirable. Poles may be wood or metal.
- Markers should *ideally* be positioned 2-4 feet beyond the trail tread (e.g. edge of pavement) with the bottom of the marker located 4 to 5 feet above ground level.
- Post the **Florida to Maine** marker on the northbound side and the **Maine to Florida** marker on the southbound side.
- Try to find matching locations for both north and southbound signs at each location.



- Choose to locate markers where trail users might be confused about what to do (e.g. where the trail crosses roadways or where it forks). The larger signs should be posted at key trailheads or access points to notify people that the ECG can be accessed there. Post the smaller markers along the route where long stretches without interruption might leave a user wondering if they are still on the ECG.
 - Arrow signs can be posted along with the trail marker to make any change in direction clear to the trail user.
 - Do not attach signs to trees, utility poles, or posts with regulatory signs (e.g., stop signs, speed limit signs), as this is not legal. If the managing authority chooses to install signs on these sort s of places, that is their responsibility.
 - When in doubt, follow MUTCD or NPS installation standards.
- Mark your base map to show where each sign will be placed. Develop a numbering system so that each sign location on your trail segment has a unique serial number.
 - Mark the location of each sign with a number and sign size symbol (red S for small sign and green L for large sign).
 - Prepare a chart to provide detail for each marker location. See example below for a model. Indicate on the chart the type of fastener to be used for each sign: screw, bolt, strapping, or bracket (see section __ for details).
 - Take digital photos of each sign location post or pole, perhaps with a person pointing to exactly where the sign will be placed. This will make it easier for those who will actually do the installation.
 - Be sure that there is a post that works well for each direction. For locations where appropriate posts or poles, suggest to the trail manager that such posts are needed. A trail's "friends" group might be willing to pay for and install such posts.

Back at home:

- Review your map for clarity and legibility. Make any needed adjustments. If information is missing you may need to return to the field.
- Create your chart, preferably electronically.
- Assess how many signs of each type, directional arrows, and fasteners of each type (i.e., screws, bolts, brackets, strapping) are needed. Prepare a sign order using the order form (p. __) and obtain the fasteners.
- Make three copies of the maps, chart, and order form: send one copy to the ECGA, one to keep on file with your state committee, and one to send to the trail manager.

d. Secure the signs and needed hardware

The ECGA maintains a supply of signs and can provide them free of charge if needed (see order form on p. 11). However, we ask that the trail managing agency or local organization cover the cost of the markers when possible, as that will extend our ability to get more signs installed.

We can keep a small supply of special screws for the signs, colored to match the signs (inven-



tory permitting). These are one-way screws that can't be removed. For the rest of signs use "off the shelf" aluminum or stainless steel screws or bolts. Brackets and strapping specifically designed for signage installation can be purchased through a number of online retailers. Many such retailers can be found using your favorite search engine and combinations of terms like "sign", "bracket", "installation", etc. A few such retailers are USA-Traffic-Signs.com, SA-SO.com, and emedco.com.

e. Installing Trail Markers

Before installing ECG trail markers, be sure that the route is indeed the officially authorized route of the ECGA. This can be accomplished by having the ECGA Trail Coordinator review your signage map.

Determine who will physically install the markers.

- if the trail managing agency is willing and able to expeditiously install the markers, encourage them to do so
- If the agency cannot do the installation, volunteers may install them. If you go this route, **be sure to get permission from the trail managing agency first.**

Secure signs, arrows, fasteners, and needed tools.

Submit a report to the managing agency (copying the ECGA) noting the date on which the markers were installed, and showing on the map any deviation from the previously determined sign locations.

v. maintaining ECG trail markers

a. ensuring that the markers remain in place

Establish a person or committee of volunteers responsible for periodic checking to see if signs have been removed, damaged or vandalized. We suggest monthly or quarterly checks at a minimum.

Prepare an Inspection Report. We'd like to get your reports on (1) how well the one way screw and "off the shelf" screws work in keeping signs in place, and (2) how well the aluminum and/or fiberglass signs stand up to the sun, scratching, and other forms of damage.

b. What to do if markers need replacement. (pending)



C. Blazing the Route

In certain cases, a simpler method of marking the route may be in order. The following instructions will facilitate the temporary marking of the route when needed.

Painted blazes for temporary use to indicate the ECG Route

The Alliance recommends that all designated sections of the ECG be signed with approved ECG trail markers. However, along the interim, on-road portions of our route, where trail markers have not yet been funded; for temporary detours or when markers are missing, white, painted blazes (2" X 6") can be used. This system of marking the trail is voluntary and is suggested for use when trail markers can not be utilized. No other temporary painted, stenciled or manufactured marks, symbols or signs are authorized, except as specified in this Signage policy.

The white 2" x 6" blaze is used to mark the Appalachian Trail and therefore is best known by trail users along the East Coast. This similarity will also reinforce the ECG as the "urban Appalachian Trail". The same blazing convention will be utilized. A single blaze will provide the user confirmation or reassurance of being on the proper route. A double blaze, one above the other, will indicate caution or continue straight ahead. Offset double blazes will indicate a change of direction (the upper blaze being in the direction of the turn).

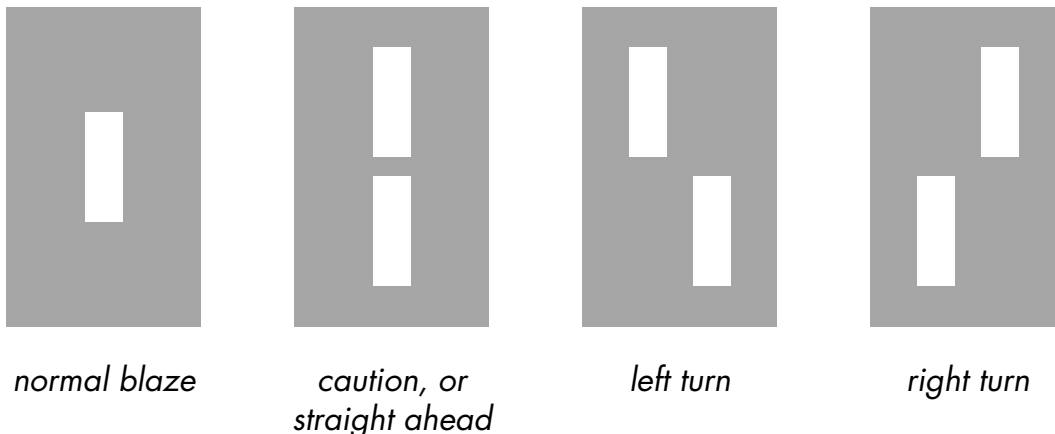


Fig. 1.19: typical trail blazes

Background

Painted blazes have been used on long distance recreational trails for many years. Painted blazes come in different colors and shapes so that a given trail can be distinguished in areas that are dense with crossing trails. Blazes do not incorporate words; they are simple geometric shapes that can be easily replicated or for use when detours or other temporary relocations are required. The first long distance trail in the US, Vermont's Long Trail, as well as the Appalachian Trail use the now familiar 2" by 6" white paint mark. The Appalachian Trail blaze shape and blazing convention has been adopted by



many hiking and equestrian trails (e.g. the Highlands horse trail in Virginia).

Trail blazes will be convenient for temporary trail sections and road sections. The majority of blazes are found on telephone poles but a significant number are also found on trees, guardrails, bridge abutments and even on the pavement. When the trail route is changed the white blazes are simply painted over with brown or neutral colored paint. Trail blazes will conflict less with highway signage regulations than trail markers on interim road sections of the ECG (although signs are preferred). Mounting a marker or sign on a telephone pole or a bridge usually requires the approval of an organization other than the trail manager. The small white blaze is understated and hardly noticed. Once your eyes are trained to pick up white blazes they are easy to spot amidst the cacophony of signs in the typical suburban or city landscape.

Before starting to blaze the route

Trail blazes are easy to produce and install. After a little practice, anyone can paint blazes. That is not to say that anyone can determine the trail route. Before going out to blaze the route, establish with your state ECG committee or with the National staff that the route is officially sanctioned by the ECGA and by the appropriate public agencies. Also, be sure that it has been field-checked. Cue sheets should have been officially issued, a sure indication that the route has been checked. Once the route has been determined, it is relatively easy to apply and maintain the blazing.

What should be blazed and how frequently should the route be blazed?

On what objects should the blazes be placed? Public objects that provide a clear line of sight to the users and sufficient height to be seen at an approaching distance are good candidates for blazing. Do not mar the front of any sign. Avoid any private object or tree, which clearly belongs in someone's yard. If unsure or uncomfortable, do not blaze the object.

What other trails use blazes for on-road sections? When first established in 1937, the Appalachian Trail was almost 50% on-road. Painted blazes were used to mark the route. Today, approximately 20 miles of the AT are still on-road and will likely remain so for the foreseeable future. Painted blazes on telephone poles, bridge abutments, sign posts, guardrails and the back of signs are all used to guide users along the route.

How often should blazes be placed? There should be a warning double blaze prior to the intersection or turn. A double blaze should be placed at the turn followed by a single confirmation within sight of the corner. The frequency of blazes should be much less than what is typical on hiking paths which wander in the woods (typically 6/mile or more). The ECG may only require blazes at turns or intersections, if the path is somewhat isolated. If marking on-road, interim route (where most temporary signage is expected), a minimum frequency of 1 blaze/mile is recommended.



Blazing Instructions

Blazes should be placed at a height that will “strike the eye” of walkers or bicyclists. Check the line of sight to ensure that there are no obstructions or overhanging tree branches. No need to blaze both sides of a road or path unless obscured line of sight or very wide road.

There are several blazing techniques. Some people prefer using a stencil. The paint is applied with a brush or spray can (we recommend not using spray cans so as not to be mistaken as a graffiti artist). The 2” X 6” stencil can be cut from cardboard or a plastic milk jug. Sometimes people outline the blaze with a felt-tip marker and then fill-in the rectangle with paint. Others use a 2" x 3" or 2" x 6" stamp made from a sponge or use a straightedge. Most people blaze freehand using the stencil as a gauge or with marks on the paint brush. The object is to have neat & uniform blazes.

Use a high quality, high-gloss exterior paint (oil or latex). To hold the paint, use a plastic squeeze bottle (old catsup or mayo containers) to apply directly to the brush or plastic 18 oz peanut butter jars for dipping. You want a relatively small container and one that can be sealed easily. Use sealable plastic bags or small cans with plastic tops (coffee cans) to place the brush after each use to keep it moist.

Frequently Asked Questions

Why use white color? Why not green or some other bright color? White is very visible and easy to match anywhere on the ECG. Colors of different shades will emerge in different locales and even in the same section as color match is not accurate.

Why not use the letters “ECG” or a stencil? A simple rectangle is easy to duplicate so that all will be identical. Even if stencils were widely duplicated, such detail has a more likely chance of being deemed graffiti.

Why not use arrows like those used on many bike rides and organized walks/runs? Arrows are more obtrusive on the visual landscape. A simple white rectangle is just not noticed unless one is focused on seeing these objects. Also, arrows might be confused with those markings placed for local events.

Can we blaze the pavement? Yes, blazes can be placed on pavement but realize that they will have limited visibility and short useful life. Blazes placed on vertical surfaces are better protected from the weather and not subject to tire wear. A confirmation blaze within sight of the intersection should be installed on both sides of a road due to limited visibility. A reassurance blaze should be placed about every mile if no marked intersections or turns.

Should blazes be maintained once trail markers are in place? No. Do not refresh blazes once adequate signage is in place. Blazes are a temporary solution.



2. ECG KIOSKS (pending)

3. OTHER SIGNAGE (pending)